

SPECIAL EDUCATIONAL NEEDS IN MAINSTREAM SCHOOLS

5 key questions for school leaders to reflect on

'Every school leader is a leader of SEND'

Pupils with Special Educational Needs and Disabilities (SEND) have the greatest need for excellent teaching.

These questions for reflection link to the 5 recommendations from the EEF's guidance report on 'Special Educational Needs in Mainstream Schools'.

These questions offer a starting point for senior leaders (aside from the school's SENCo) and governors/trustees to review their own knowledge, skills and impact on outcomes for all pupils with SEND.

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EEF guidance recommendation	Questions for reflection
1 Create a positive and supportive environment for all pupils, without exception.	• In considering the most prevalent area of need in your school—e.g. communication and interaction - does your SEND provision address this? • How do you promote positive relationships, active engagement and well-being for all pupils including for those pupils with SEND and their parents ? • Are materials on paper and online accessible to all? What materials in particular do you refer to—give examples.
2 Build ongoing, holistic understanding of your pupils and their needs.	• What percentage of pupils are on the SEND register in your school and how does this compare to local and national averages? • What is the process for a child to be placed on the SEND register? • What are teachers' attitudes and approaches towards pupils with SEND? • How does your school interpret and implement the graduated approach of assess, plan, do, review? How is this communicated between the pupil and their families and teachers in school? • How is support from specialist professionals accessed and monitored?

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3 Ensure all pupils have access to high quality teaching.	• Is your SENCo a member of the leadership team and what is the purpose of their role in that team? • How frequently is SEND on the agenda of SLT meetings? • How does the SENCo meaningfully input in to teaching and learning decisions in school? • How consistent is high-quality teaching across the school? • What staff training is required? (Strategies to emphasise for pupils with SEND might include: flexible grouping, cognitive and metacognitive strategies explicit instruction, use of technology and scaffolding.)
4 Compliment high-quality teaching with carefully selected small-group and one-to-one interventions.	• What SEND provision is in place within your school/MAT? • What small group and one-to-one provision is in place? • What is in place to monitor and evaluate the impact of this provision? Are the interventions high quality, structured and targeted? • How do you monitor unintended consequences such as interventions becoming a barrier to inclusion?
5 Work effectively with teaching assistants (TAs).	• How much of your SEND provision is delivered by highly skilled and qualified teachers? • How much of this provision is delivered by TAs? • How do TAs supplement (not replace) the classroom teacher? • How is TA deployment reviewed each year? • How are TAs involved in training and development in school?